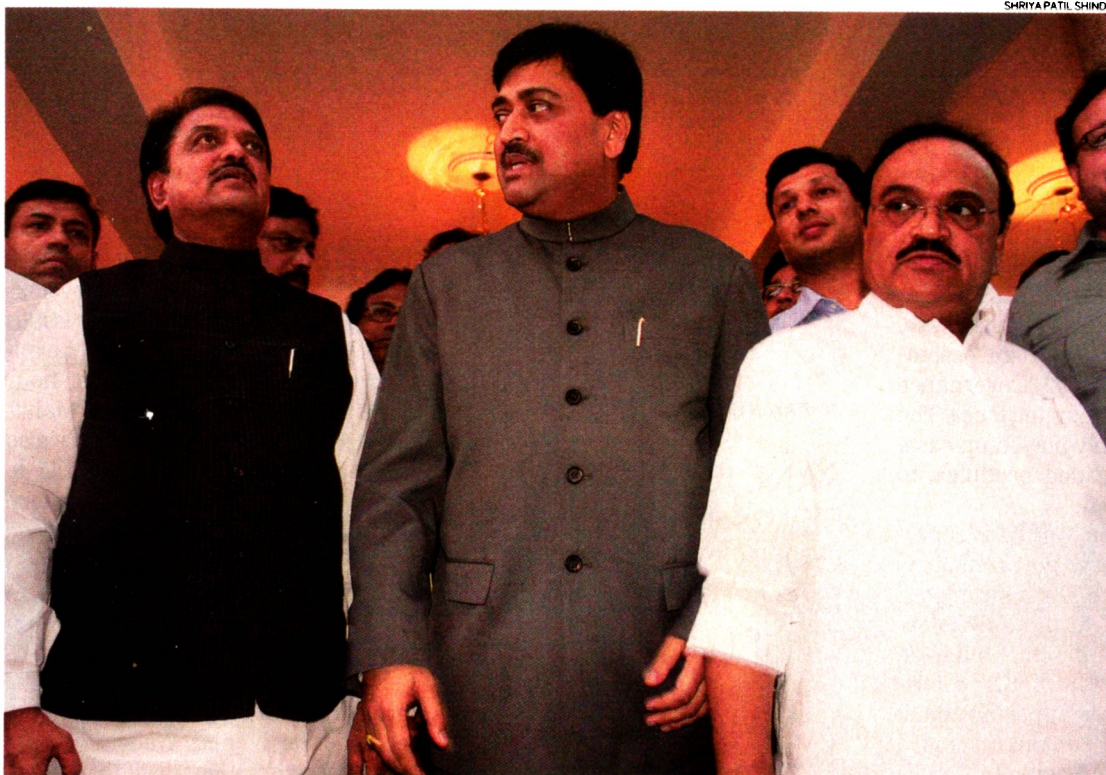




VILASRAO DESHMUKH, CHAVAN AND BHUJBAL DURING THE SWEARING-IN CEREMONY

# An Eye on THE FUTURE

The new council of ministers has been picked with next year's Lok Sabha elections as the sole criterion

| By Aditi Pai |

**S**ilent, staunch loyalty begets handsome rewards in the Congress. And Maharashtra's new Chief Minister Ashok Chavan is a true Congressman in that sense because he knows the rules of the game. Far from being a high-decibel politician, the urbane business graduate bagged the hot seat thanks to his low profile and non-controversial image. Narayan Rane could have done well, had he learnt the same. While Chavan and his team of 38 ministers have not thrown up any surprises, the strategy behind choos-

ing the right man for the right job shows that the Democratic Front (DF) is in poll mode.

The new chief minister has the right credentials. He is the late Congress leader Shankarrao Chavan's son. The 50-year-old, who won his first election at the age of 28, is a science graduate with a business management degree from a premier institute in Nashik. Over the years, he has held several portfolios such as revenue, transport, industries and cultural affairs. Chavan is also a fresh young face that should appeal to voters, come the

polls. "He was backed by Rahul Gandhi, who wants to encourage young people to take up positions of power," says a senior Congress leader.

But the fly in the ointment is Rane. After his suspension from the Congress, the youth wing of the party has suspended all his key supporters as well, including his son Nitesh who was its general secretary. Rane has few choices left. Sources say the former Sainik is working on weaning away a few MLAs to split the Congress. However, his loyalist and Gadchiroli MLA Vijay Wadettiwar has been given a ministerial berth to prevent him from rebelling. It is believed that Rane plans to form a new party just before the Lok Sabha elections, and using his sizeable support base in Konkan, tie up with friend Raj Thackeray's party. The two leaders are reportedly in talks with other smaller state parties.

A closer look at Chavan's team shows that the mix is more about keeping caste and regional calculations in mind rather than improving governance. Ministers who were asked to step down on account of criminal cases have also been brought in to balance